

HEMANT CHAWLA



Time is money, especially for business travellers who constantly shuttle from city to city. As they turn to charter services to save precious hours, operators queue up to buy aircraft.

■ **By Nandini Vaish**

When Dabur CEO Sunil Duggal had to travel from Delhi to Amritsar for a dealer conference, he asked his assistant to book a ticket. As the airline's schedule did not match his own, his assistant simply booked a plane, a seven-seater Hawker, to accommodate some senior managers and top dealers. The journey, which would have taken a full hour by a commercial flight, took them 40 minutes. The cost: Rs 4 lakh. Compare this with the one-way, business class fare of a normal aircraft: Rs 9,000 per head.

India, home to more than one lakh millionaires, is demanding more and more air charter services. What is fuelling this market? According to the Centre for Asia-Pacific Aviation, two-thirds of total private aviation flight time is used for business purposes. With a charter, business travellers, who spend considerable time shuttling

between cities, can avoid flight delays and lengthy check-in procedures, cut back on travel time, cover four to five cities in a day and still be back home for dinner.

According to Ernst & Young, there are 32 air charter companies plying in the country, but the market is highly fragmented, with most of them owning just one or two aircraft. In addition to Oberoi Aviation and Taj Air—which started operating charters in 1996 and 2002, respectively, largely for company use and for hotel guests—new entrants range from Ran Air to frac-

▲ **Sanjay Godhwani**

The CEO and MD of Ran Air, one of the largest players in the market for charter services, is buying up pre-owned aircraft at a bargain. Godhwani says, "This is the right time to enter the market." He wants to take his fleet size up to 14 by 2009. Ran Air's aircraft, each of which logs in 600 hours per year, have state-of-the-art entertainment systems with an LCD screen for each seat.

tional ownership company Club One Air, GMR Aviation, Mumbai-based Invision Air, Singapore's BJets, co-owned by the Tatas, and the Warren Buffet-owned NetJets, in partnership with Porsche distributor Ashish Chordia. "Given the wealth being generated in India, it's less about saving and more about enjoying life," says Mark Baier, CEO, BJets.

While there is nothing like owning one's own jet, the cost can be prohibitive. It only make sense if one flies at least 400 hours a year. An entry-level private jet, such as the four-passenger very light jet (VLJ) Eclipse 500, costs \$1.8 million (Rs 7.2 crore), apart

OPERATOR AIRCRAFT

Club One Air	2 choppers + 7 jets + 10 ordered
Ran Air	1 chopper + 7 jets + 2 ordered
GMR Aviation	3 jets
Taj Air	2 jets + 1 ordered
Oberoi Aviation	2 jets
Invision Air	20 jets ordered
BJets	50 jets ordered